

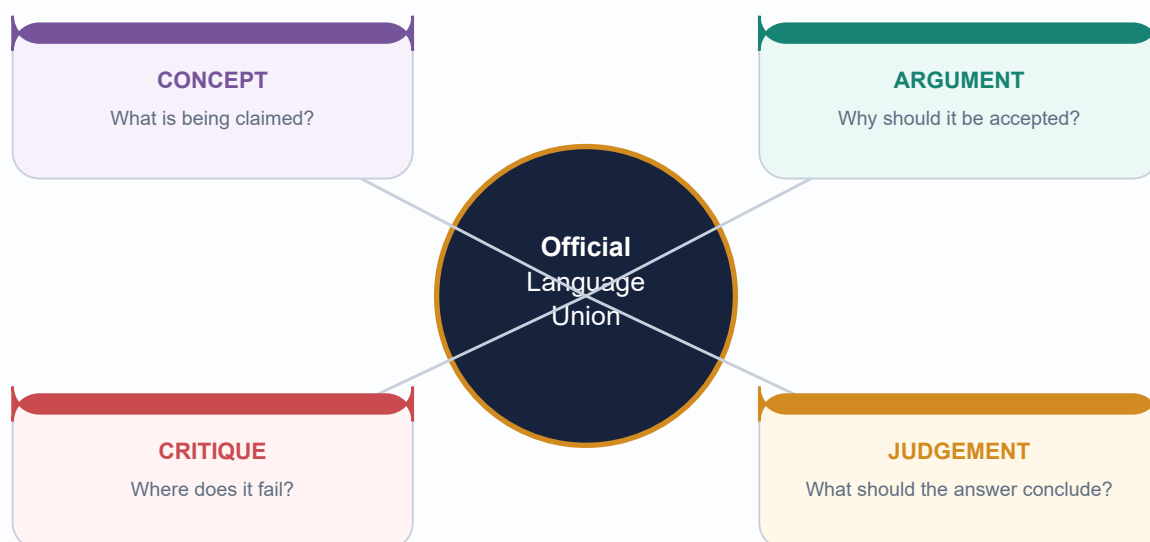
UPSC GS-I / GS-II POLITY

Official Language of the Union: Articles 343 to 351

Integrated Basic + Advanced Course

11 deep-learning modules | Constituent Assembly Compromise to the 2024 Classical Language List
Union and regional language scheme, judiciary provisions, special directives, Eighth Schedule evolution
and Mains frameworks

Prepared from the verified Polity knowledge base and the completed guided session



Facts from official sources | Inferences clearly marked | No fabricated data

HIGH UPSC RELEVANCE

HIGH

1. Part XVII at a Glance: The Constitutional Language Scheme

GS-I / GS-II
Polity -
Constitutional
Scheme

NEWS TRIGGER

Recurring federal disputes over the three-language formula keep the original constitutional compromise on language -- one official language, not one national language -- at the centre of current political debate.

PART XVII: OFFICIAL LANGUAGE (ARTICLES 343-351)

Part XVII

Language of the Union Arts 343-344 - Hindi as official language; the English transition.	Regional Languages Arts 345-347 - state choice and linguistic minority protection.
Judiciary and Laws Arts 348-349 - English for courts and authoritative legal texts.	Special Directives Arts 350-351 - grievance redressal, minority education, Hindi development.

STATIC THEORY

- Part XVII of the Constitution is organised into five practical blocks: the language of the Union, regional-language freedom, the language of the judiciary and laws, special protective directives, and the Eighth Schedule as an attached list of recognised languages.
- The single most important distinction running through the whole Part is between an 'official' language, used for government business, and a 'national' language, which the Constitution does not declare for any language.

MEMORY HOOK

Part XVII has five blocks: Union (343-4), Regions (345-7), Judiciary (348-9), Directives (350-1), plus the Eighth Schedule as an attached list.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

- Part XVII of the Constitution covers Articles 343 to 351.
- Hindi in Devanagari script is the official language of the Union under Article 343.
- India has no constitutionally declared national language.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Hindi is India's national language.

CORRECT: Hindi is the official language of the Union; India has no national language.

MAINS ANGLE

Discuss the constitutional wisdom of having an official language but no national language.

STUDY LINK

Polity -> Part XVII -> Constituent Assembly language debates

HIGH

2. Language of the Union: Articles 343-344

GS-II Polity -
Union Language
Scheme

NEWS TRIGGER

The long transition from a 15-year English window to its indefinite continuation under the Official Languages Act, 1963 is a frequently tested chronology.

INTRO & ORIGIN

TIMELINE

1950 — Constitution commences; Hindi in Devanagari script becomes the official language of the Union under Article 343; English is to continue for 15 years.

1955 — First Official Language Commission constituted under B.G. Kher.

1957 — Parliamentary committee under G.B. Pant examines the Commission's report.

1963 — Official Languages Act passed, allowing English to continue indefinitely alongside Hindi.

1965 — The original 15-year transition period for English under Article 343 ends.

1967 — Official Languages Act amended, making English use compulsory in certain cases, in response to anti-Hindi agitation.

KEY DATA

Provision	Content
Art 343(1)	Hindi in Devanagari script is the official language of the Union; numerals are in international (Indian) form
Art 343(2)	English continues for 15 years from commencement (1950-1965)
Art 344	Provides for Official Language Commissions at the 5th and 10th years, and a Parliamentary Committee to examine their reports

STATIC THEORY

- Article 343's reference to 'international form of Indian numerals' means Arabic numerals, not Devanagari numerals -- a frequently tested nuance.
- The Official Languages Act, 1963 was itself amended in 1967 to make English use compulsory in certain cases, a direct legislative response to anti-Hindi agitation in the South.

MEMORY HOOK

343 = HINDI in Devanagari script with international numerals; 344 = COMMISSION at year 5 and year 10.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Hindi in Devanagari script is the official language of the Union under Article 343.
2. Numerals under Article 343 are in international (Indian) form, not Devanagari.
3. The first Official Language Commission was constituted in 1955 under B.G. Kher.
4. The Official Languages Act, 1963 keeps English in use indefinitely.

UPSC TRAPS

- WRONG:** Article 343 requires the use of Devanagari numerals as well as script.
- CORRECT:** Numerals are in the international (Indian) form, not Devanagari.
- WRONG:** English use ended in 1965 as originally planned under Article 343.
- CORRECT:** The Official Languages Act, 1963 keeps English in use indefinitely.

MAINS ANGLE

Examine why Parliament chose to extend English indefinitely through ordinary legislation rather than let the original 15-year clause under Article 343 lapse.

STUDY LINK

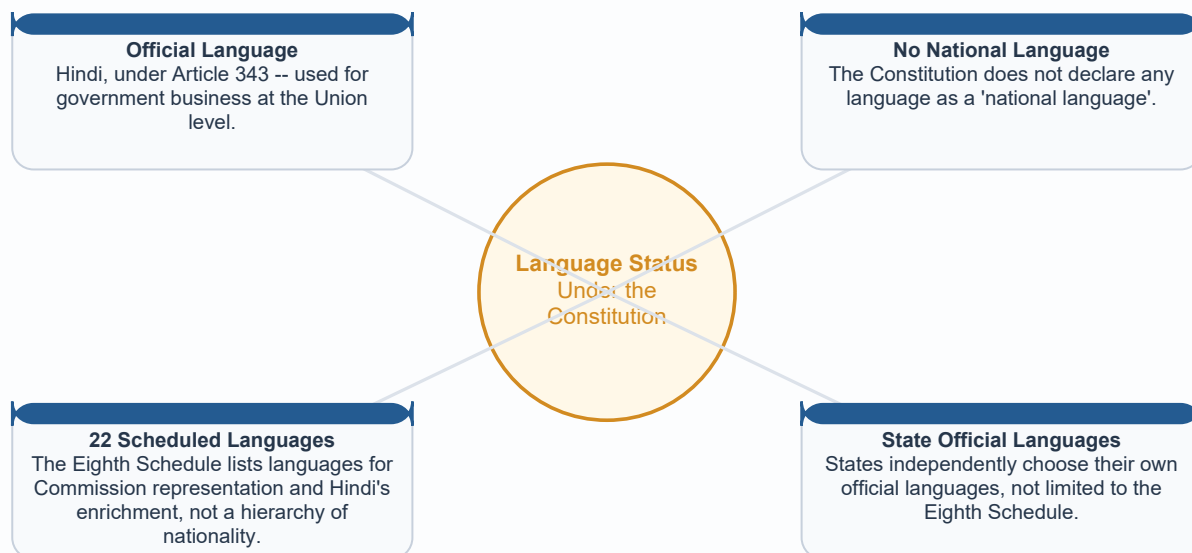
Polity -> Constituent Assembly Debates -> the Munshi-Ayyangar language formula

HIGH**3. 'Official' Not 'National': The Biggest Trap**

GS-I / GS-II
Polity -
Frequently
Tested
Distinctions

NEWS TRIGGER

Objective-format questions on the Constitution's language provisions repeatedly test whether candidates can distinguish an official language from a national language.

OFFICIAL LANGUAGE VS NATIONAL LANGUAGE**STATIC THEORY**

- This distinction is one of the most frequently tested facts in the entire topic: India's multilingual federal design deliberately avoided declaring a single 'national language' to accommodate linguistic diversity.
- The Eighth Schedule's 22 languages hold a distinct constitutional status from an 'official language' -- inclusion in the Schedule does not by itself make a language official anywhere.

MEMORY HOOK

OFFICIAL, yes; NATIONAL, no -- the single most repeated trap on this topic.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Hindi is the official language of the Union, not a national language.
2. The Constitution does not designate any language as India's national language.
3. Being listed in the Eighth Schedule does not make a language 'official' by itself.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: The Eighth Schedule lists India's national languages.

CORRECT: It lists languages for Commission representation and Hindi's enrichment; India has no national language.

MAINS ANGLE

Discuss whether India's decision to avoid a single national language has strengthened or complicated its federal linguistic politics.

STUDY LINK

Polity -> Linguistic Diversity -> reorganisation of states on linguistic lines, 1956

HIGH**4. Regional Languages: Articles 345-347**

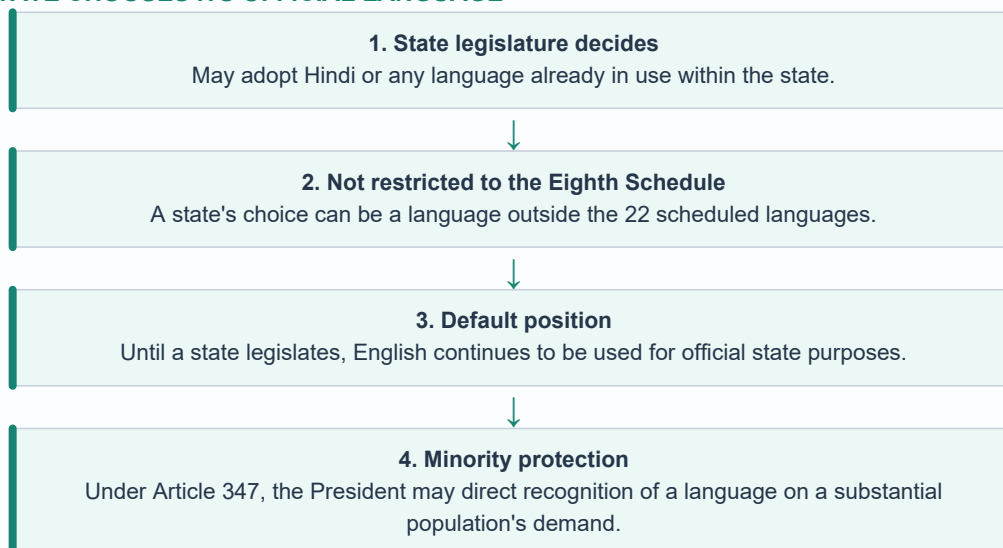
GS-II Polity -
Regional
Language
Freedom

NEWS TRIGGER

State assemblies periodically debate adopting or changing their official language, exercising the freedom the Constitution grants under Article 345.

KEY DATA

Article	Provision
Art 345	A state legislature may adopt Hindi or any language(s) in use in the state as its official language(s); until then, English continues
Art 346	English continues for inter-state and Centre-state communication until Parliament decides otherwise; states may agree to use Hindi between themselves
Art 347	On demand, if a substantial population wants it, the President may direct official recognition of a language in a state, protecting linguistic minorities

HOW A STATE CHOOSES ITS OFFICIAL LANGUAGE

STATIC THEORY

- A state's freedom to select its own official language is not limited to the 22 languages of the Eighth Schedule -- some states have adopted languages outside that list.
- Article 347 exists specifically to protect linguistic minorities within a state by allowing the President to direct official recognition of their language on a substantial demand.

MEMORY HOOK

A state's choice is FREE -- it is not locked to the Eighth Schedule.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. A state legislature may adopt Hindi or any language in use in the state as its official language.
2. A state's official-language choice is not restricted to the Eighth Schedule.
3. Article 347 protects linguistic minorities through Presidential recognition on demand.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: A state's official language must be one of the 22 Eighth Schedule languages.

CORRECT: States are not restricted to the Eighth Schedule when choosing an official language.

MAINS ANGLE

Discuss how Articles 345-347 embed linguistic federalism within the Union's overall Hindi-English official language framework.

STUDY LINK

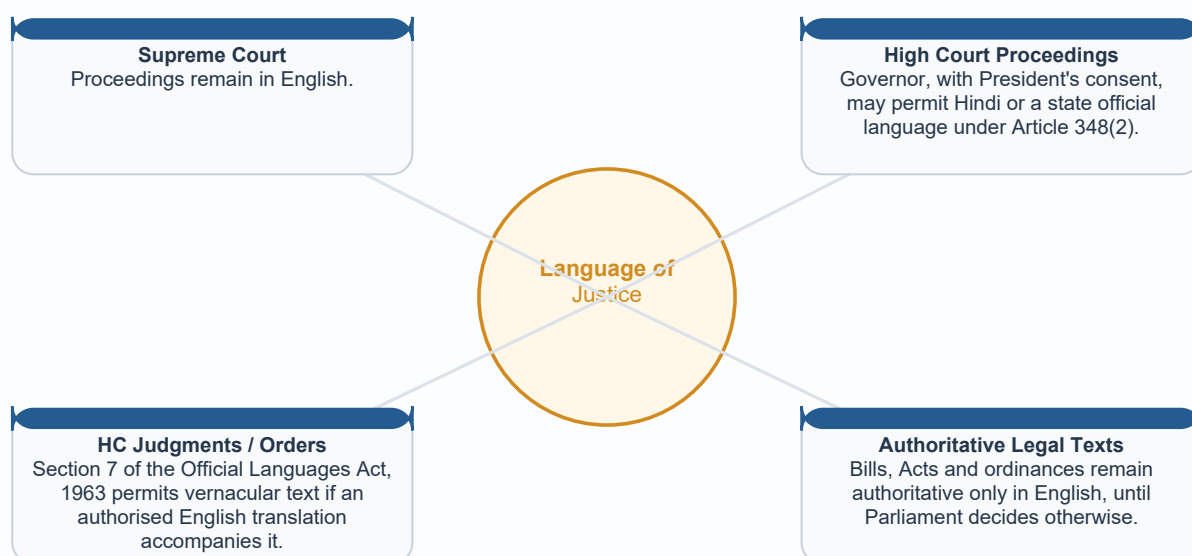
Polity -> Eighth Schedule -> state language choices

HIGH**5. Judiciary and Laws: Articles 348-349**

**GS-II Polity -
Language of
Judiciary**

NEWS TRIGGER

Demands to allow more regional-language use in High Courts keep the distinction between 'proceedings' and 'judgments' under the Constitution and the Official Languages Act relevant.

ENGLISH IN COURTS AND LAW

KEY DATA

Provision	Content
Art 348(1)	Proceedings of the Supreme Court and every High Court, and authoritative texts of Bills, Acts, ordinances, orders, rules and regulations, are in English until Parliament decides otherwise
Art 348(2)	A Governor may, with the President's prior consent, authorise the use of Hindi or another state's official language in High Court proceedings (not judgments)
Official Languages Act, 1963, s.7	Separately permits Hindi or a state official language in High Court judgments, decrees or orders, if accompanied by an authorised English translation
Art 349	Special procedure for enacting certain language-related laws during the transitional period

STATIC THEORY

- Article 348(2) covers High Court proceedings, not judgments; the separate statutory route under Section 7 of the Official Languages Act, 1963 is what permits vernacular High Court judgments, decrees or orders, subject to an authorised English translation.
- This two-track design allows regional-language use in courtroom proceedings while preserving a uniform, authoritative English text of the formal legal record.

MEMORY HOOK

Art 348(2) covers PROCEEDINGS via Governor plus President; Section 7 of the 1963 Act covers JUDGMENTS with an English translation attached.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Supreme Court and High Court proceedings, and authoritative legal texts, are in English unless Parliament decides otherwise.
2. A Governor needs the President's prior consent to authorise Hindi in High Court proceedings.
3. Section 7 of the Official Languages Act, 1963 permits Hindi in High Court judgments if an authorised English translation accompanies them.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: A Governor's consent alone is enough to allow Hindi in High Court proceedings.

CORRECT: The Governor also needs the President's prior consent under Article 348(2).

WRONG: High Court judgments in Hindi are permitted without any accompanying English text.

CORRECT: They must be accompanied by an authorised English translation under Section 7 of the 1963 Act.

MAINS ANGLE

Examine the tension between access to justice in a regional language and the need for a uniform, authoritative legal text in English.

STUDY LINK

Polity -> Judiciary -> High Court jurisdiction and procedure

HIGH

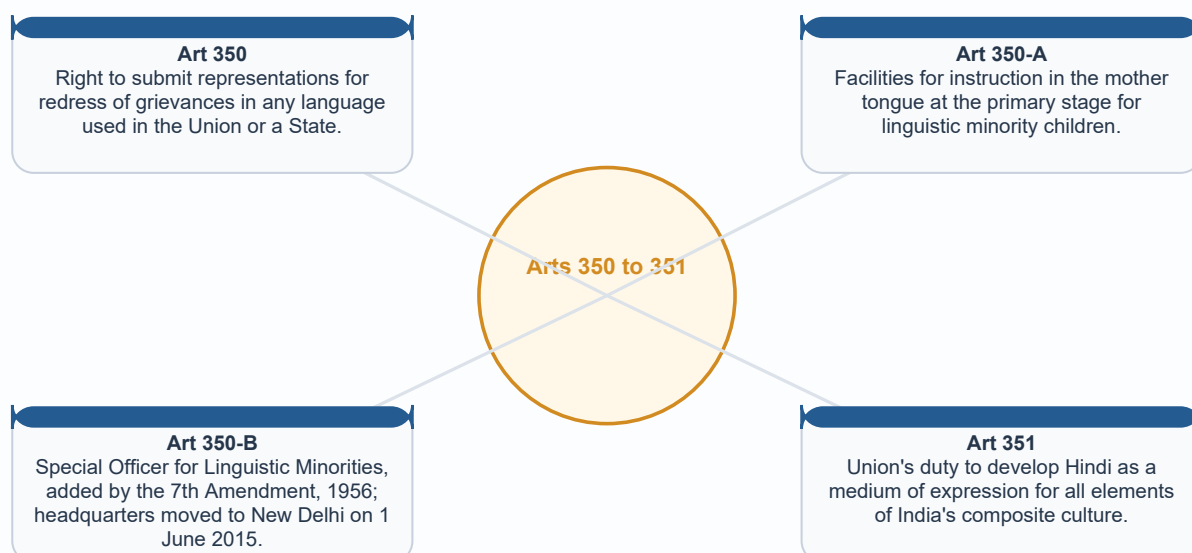
6. Special Directives: Articles 350 to 351

GS-I / GS-II
Polity - Minority
Protection
Provisions

NEWS TRIGGER

The relocation of the Special Officer for Linguistic Minorities' headquarters to New Delhi in 2015 is a lesser-known but exam-relevant administrative detail under Article 350-B.

SPECIAL LANGUAGE DIRECTIVES



KEY DATA

Article	Provision	Key Date
Art 350	Grievance redressal in any language used	Original Constitution
Art 350-A	Mother-tongue instruction for linguistic minorities	Original Constitution
Art 350-B	Special Officer for Linguistic Minorities	Added by 7th Amendment, 1956; HQ moved to New Delhi, 1 June 2015
Art 351	Union's duty to develop Hindi	Original Constitution

STATIC THEORY

- Article 350-B was not part of the original Constitution; it was inserted by the 7th Constitutional Amendment, 1956, alongside the linguistic reorganisation of states.
- Article 351 frames the development of Hindi as enrichment 'by assimilating' the forms and expressions used in Hindustani and other Eighth Schedule languages, rather than displacing them.

MEMORY HOOK

350 = GRIEVANCE; 350-A = MOTHER TONGUE; 350-B = SPECIAL OFFICER; 351 = DEVELOP HINDI.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Article 350 protects the right to submit grievances in any language used in the Union or a State.
2. Article 350-A provides for mother-tongue instruction at the primary stage for linguistic minorities.
3. Article 350-B was added by the 7th Constitutional Amendment, 1956.
4. Article 351 places a duty on the Union to develop Hindi.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Article 350-B was part of the original Constitution of 1950.

CORRECT: It was added later, by the 7th Constitutional Amendment, 1956.

MAINS ANGLE

Discuss how Articles 350 to 351 protect linguistic minorities even as the Union simultaneously promotes the development of Hindi.

STUDY LINK

Polity -> 7th Constitutional Amendment, 1956
-> reorganisation-era provisions

HIGH

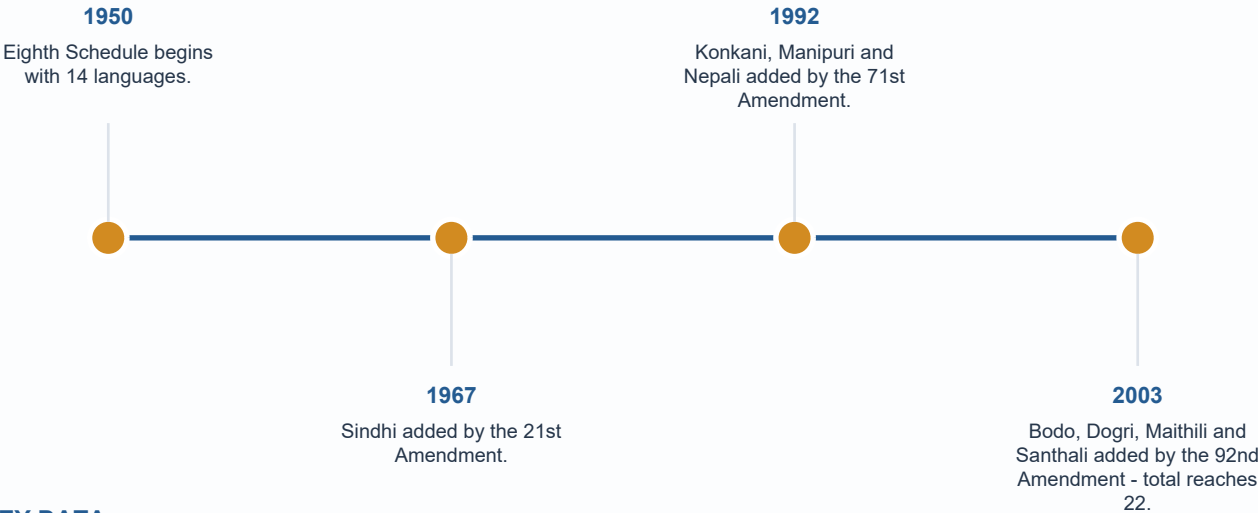
7. The Eighth Schedule: From 14 to 22 Languages

GS-I / GS-II
Polity - Eighth
Schedule
Evolution

NEWS TRIGGER

Ongoing demands to add roughly 38 more languages keep the Eighth Schedule's expansion history -- from 14 to 22 languages across three amendments -- exam-relevant.

GROWTH OF THE EIGHTH SCHEDULE



KEY DATA

Amendment	Year	Languages Added
21st Amendment	1967	Sindhi
71st Amendment	1992	Konkani, Manipuri, Nepali
92nd Amendment	2003	Bodo, Dogri, Maithili, Santhali

STATIC THEORY

- The Eighth Schedule serves two purposes: representation on the Official Language Commission, and use as a source for the enrichment of Hindi under Article 351.
- The Schedule has grown from 14 languages at commencement to 22 today, through three separate constitutional amendments in 1967, 1992 and 2003.

MEMORY HOOK

14 to 22: SINDHI (1967), then KONKANI/MANIPURI/NEPALI (1992), then BODO/DOGRI/MAITHILI/SANTHALI (2003).

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. The Eighth Schedule began with 14 languages in 1950 and now lists 22.
2. Sindhi was added by the 21st Amendment in 1967.
3. Konkani, Manipuri and Nepali were added by the 71st Amendment in 1992.
4. Bodo, Dogri, Maithili and Santhali were added by the 92nd Amendment in 2003.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: The Eighth Schedule currently lists 18 languages.

CORRECT: It lists 22 languages, having started with 14.

MAINS ANGLE

Should the Eighth Schedule be expanded? Weigh linguistic justice against administrative feasibility, in light of pending demands to add roughly 38 more languages.

STUDY LINK

Polity -> Constitutional Amendments -> 21st, 71st, 92nd Amendments

HIGH**8. Committee of Parliament on Official Language**

GS-II Polity -
Parliamentary
Committees

NEWS TRIGGER

The Committee of Parliament on Official Language periodically submits reports reviewing the pace of Hindi's adoption in official work, keeping its composition and conventions relevant.

KEY DATA

Feature	Detail
Established under	Official Languages Act, 1963
Constituted in	1976
Composition	30 members - 20 from the Lok Sabha, 10 from the Rajya Sabha
Chair (by convention)	Union Home Minister
Function	Reviews progress in the use of Hindi and reports to the President

HOW THE COMMITTEE FUNCTIONS

STATIC THEORY

- The Committee was constituted in 1976 under the authority of the Official Languages Act, 1963, though the Act itself was passed thirteen years earlier.
- Chairing by the Union Home Minister is a settled convention rather than an explicit statutory mandate, similar to several other convention-based parliamentary practices.

MEMORY HOOK

30 members = 20 (Lok Sabha) + 10 (Rajya Sabha); chaired by the HOME MINISTER by convention; reports to the PRESIDENT.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. The Committee of Parliament on Official Language has 30 members: 20 from the Lok Sabha and 10 from the Rajya Sabha.
2. It was constituted in 1976 under the Official Languages Act, 1963.
3. By convention, the Union Home Minister chairs the Committee.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: The Committee reports directly to Parliament without any Presidential role.

CORRECT: It reviews Hindi's progress and reports to the President.

MAINS ANGLE

Assess the role of the Committee of Parliament on Official Language in monitoring the pace of Hindi's official adoption without displacing English or regional languages.

STUDY LINK

Polity -> Parliamentary Committees -> committees on statutory subjects

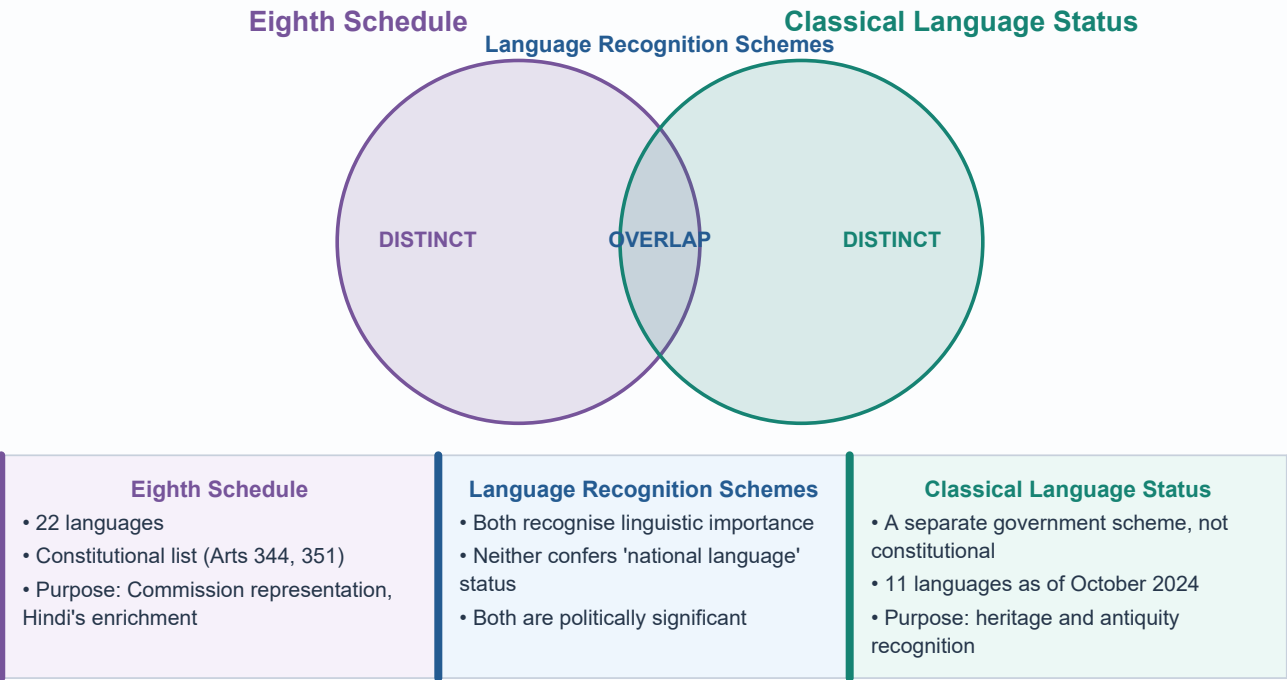
HIGH**9. Classical Language Status vs the Eighth Schedule**

GS-I Polity and
Culture -
Language
Recognition
Schemes

NEWS TRIGGER

The October 2024 addition of Marathi, Pali, Prakrit, Assamese and Bengali to the Classical Language list, taking the total to 11, has renewed confusion between this scheme and the Eighth Schedule.

EIGHTH SCHEDULE VS CLASSICAL LANGUAGE STATUS



KEY DATA

Year	Language(s) Given Classical Status
2004	Tamil
2005	Sanskrit
2008	Kannada, Telugu
2013	Malayalam
2014	Odia
Oct 2024	Marathi, Pali, Prakrit, Assamese, Bengali (total reaches 11)

STATIC THEORY

- Classical Language status is granted under a separate government scheme based on criteria such as antiquity and a distinct literary tradition; it carries no constitutional status and is unrelated to the Eighth Schedule.
- The October 2024 additions took the total number of Classical Languages to 11, up from 6 recognised between 2004 and 2014.

MEMORY HOOK

The Eighth Schedule is **CONSTITUTIONAL**, with 22 languages; Classical status is a **SEPARATE SCHEME**, with 11 languages after October 2024.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Classical Language status is a separate government scheme, not part of the Eighth Schedule.
2. As of October 2024, 11 languages hold Classical Language status.
3. Tamil (2004) and Sanskrit (2005) were the first two languages to receive this status.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Classical Language status is granted under the Eighth Schedule.

CORRECT: It is a separate government scheme, unrelated to the Eighth Schedule.

MAINS ANGLE

Distinguish the constitutional Eighth Schedule from the executive Classical Language scheme, and discuss the policy rationale for each.

STUDY LINK

Culture -> Ministry of Culture -> Classical Language recognition criteria

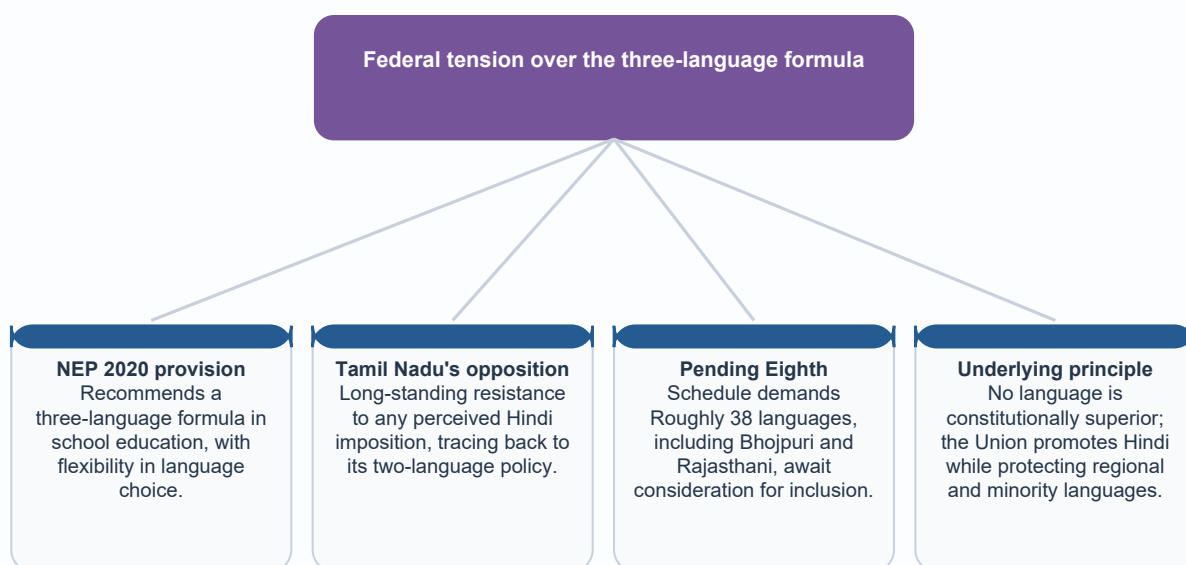
HIGH

10. Federal Politics of Language: The Three-Language Formula

GS-I / GS-II
Polity - Federal
Language
Politics

NEWS TRIGGER

The National Education Policy 2020's three-language formula continues to draw sustained opposition from Tamil Nadu, reviving one of India's oldest federal language disputes.

THE THREE-LANGUAGE FORMULA AND FEDERAL TENSION**STATIC THEORY**

- The three-language formula under the National Education Policy, 2020 recommends flexible language learning in schools, but has met resistance in Tamil Nadu, which has followed a two-language policy since the 1960s.
- This dispute sits alongside pending demands to add roughly 38 additional languages, including Bhojpuri and Rajasthani, to the Eighth Schedule -- both reflecting the same underlying federal-linguistic tension.

MEMORY HOOK

The NEP's three-language formula meets Tamil Nadu's two-language policy -- the recurring flashpoint of India's language federalism.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. The National Education Policy, 2020 recommends a three-language formula in school education.
2. Tamil Nadu has opposed the formula, citing concerns over Hindi imposition.
3. Demands to add roughly 38 languages to the Eighth Schedule remain pending.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: The three-language formula makes Hindi compulsory in every state.

CORRECT: It recommends flexibility in language choice; it does not mandate a specific language.

MAINS ANGLE

The three-language formula and the federal tension over Hindi imposition.

STUDY LINK

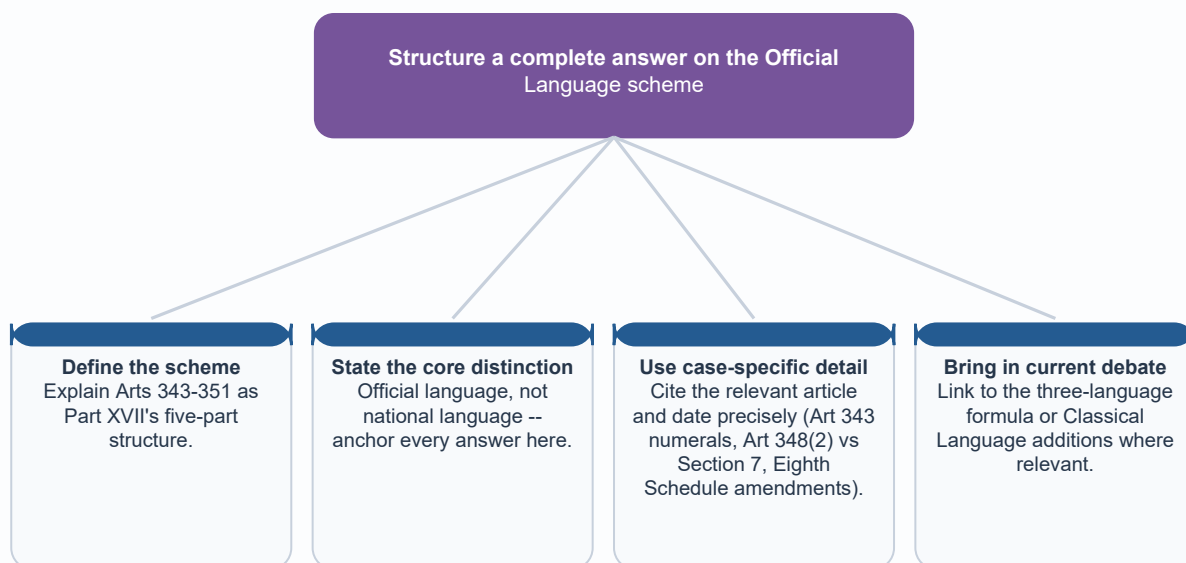
Polity -> Cooperative and Competitive
Federalism -> language politics

HIGH**11. Comparisons, Traps and the Mains Framework**

GS-I / GS-II
Polity -
Answer-Writing
Framework

NEWS TRIGGER

A single integrated framework linking Articles 343-351, the Eighth Schedule and current language debates is essential for a complete Mains answer on this topic.

MAINS ANSWER FRAMEWORK: LANGUAGE PROVISIONS

KEY DATA

Confusable Pair	Correct Distinction
Official language vs national language	Hindi is the official language (Art 343); India has no national language
Art 348(2) vs Section 7, OL Act 1963	Art 348(2) covers HC proceedings via Governor and President; Section 7 covers HC judgments with an English translation
Eighth Schedule vs Classical Language status	Eighth Schedule is constitutional (22 languages); Classical status is a separate scheme (11 languages)
Art 345 state choice vs Eighth Schedule	States are free to choose any language, not limited to the 22 scheduled languages

STATIC THEORY

- A complete Mains answer on this topic should define Part XVII's five-part structure, anchor on the official-versus-national distinction, use precise article-level detail, and connect to a live current debate such as the three-language formula.
- The conclusion should note that India's federal design promotes Hindi through the Union's duty under Article 351, while constitutionally protecting linguistic diversity through Articles 345 to 350-B.

MEMORY HOOK

DEFINE the five-part scheme, **ANCHOR** on official-not-national, **CITE** precise articles, **LINK** to current debate, **CONCLUDE** on balance.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Hindi is the official language of the Union; India has no national language.
2. The Eighth Schedule (22 languages) and Classical Language status (11 languages) are distinct schemes.
3. States are free to choose any official language, not limited to the Eighth Schedule.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: All the provisions in Part XVII apply uniformly across every state.

CORRECT: Articles 345-347 specifically preserve each state's freedom to choose its own official language arrangement.

MAINS ANGLE

India has an official language but no national language. Discuss the constitutional wisdom of this scheme, and weigh linguistic justice against administrative feasibility.

STUDY LINK

Polity -> Full-Topic Revision -> Official Language integrated framework